

# Alternative DESTINATION

Hyderabad is the least homophobic and most sexually tolerant of Indian cities, partly because of its multicultural heritage

By Sudhakar Krishnamurti

And, ladies and gentlemen, the Oscar goes to Hyderabad. Even *Titanic* had received only 14 Oscar nominations and won 11. But Hyderabad, India's second largest city, has won more than 15 firsts in the INDIA TODAY-AC Nielsen-ORG MARG sex survey, 2008, thus confirming that it is unarguably the sex capital of India. Let's look at these Sex Oscars. The city leads India in these arenas: highest incidence of adultery, wife-swapping, sex with prostitutes, sanction and practice of homosexuality, use of sex toys, practice of underage sex, role-playing, different positions, sexual adventurousness, bisexuality, heterosexual anal sex, use of pornography, partner use of pornography, video pornography, and even making of one's own porn videos. Hyderabad's sexuality has been chronicled in books like *With Respect to Sex* and *Asian Homosexuality* among others.

During the reign of the Nizams (1724-1948), Hyderabad was prosperous. Sex was celebrated in this time, and polygamy and alternative sexuality, including homosexuality and paedophilia were accepted as a part of life. Hijras, castrated eunuchs who guarded harems, often doubled as homosexual partners. There is even a record of two of an erstwhile Nizam's sons stabbing one another over the love of a beautiful Hijra named Rehman. Migration of people to Hyderabad brought in aspects of feudal and Devadasi sexuality. It is not surprising, therefore, that so many Hyderabadis patronise prostitutes, swap wives and practice adultery. The city's prosperity has

attracted many young men and women from faraway places, many of whom are ready to mingle, whether married or single. The tolerant and permissive sexual ethos of Hyderabad has also made it a favourite LGBT (Lesbian, Gay, Bisexual & Trans-sexual) destination. A disturbing downside to all this is that Andhra Pradesh has the highest numbers of HIV/AIDS-afflicted. Another worry is the recent spurt in homosexual sex crimes and killings.

LGBTs are everywhere in the city. The Yahoo chat group, Gay Hyderabad, ranks among the top ten. There are gay bars, gay groups like Mithrudu, and we even have our own Ashok Row Kavi, Hoshang Merchant, who authored *Yaarana: Gay Writing from India*, and other books. The real reason why Hyderabad tops gay lists is because it is sexually tolerant. I'd even say "evolved". It is perhaps, the least homophobic of Indian cities. One sees men holding hands and nobody gives them a second glance. The same is true of lesbians.

There is another reason. Californian law is homophobic. San Francisco, for example, has a higher homosexual population than many other cities in the US. In contrast, Indian law is homophobic, and gays face a lot of public ostracism. In the absence of legal sanction, societal sanction becomes an important determinant. It can be stated that Hyderabad is the nation's LGBT headquarters at a time when a campaign is on to recognise alternative sexuality.

*The writer is an andrologist, a sexual medicine expert and author of Sex is Not a Four-Letter Word.*

HYDERABAD IS A FAVOURITE LESBIAN, GAY, BISEXUAL AND TRANS-SEXUAL CENTRE



PROUD TO  
BE GAY

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